officers, and are marauding all over the country. It is not actually any business of ours, but interrupts our communications with Afghanistan . . .'[12]

This was an understatement. Not only did supply trains heading up the passes into Afghanistan often have to fight their way through ambushes and frequent attempts to hijack the baggage animals, there were a growing number of credible reports that senior Sikh sardars in Lahore and Rawalpindi were actively sheltering rebel Barakzai and Durrani chiefs and other Afghan rebel leaders, giving them a base in the Punjab and the hills around Peshawar from which they could strike back at British troops over the border in Afghanistan. The authorities in India thus found themselves in a difficult situation: the Sikh sardars were still nominal allies, but in reality many were doing all they could to undermine the British in Afghanistan. Before long, Auckland was beginning to flirt with the hawkish plans suggested by Colvin to annex the Punjab in order to close down the insurgents' bases and ease the passage of supplies up to the front: 'I am of the opinion that if Sikh authority should be further dissolved, its restoration is not to be regarded as a thing practicable,' he wrote. 'Things have not yet reached a crisis, but they appear to be fast approaching it.'[13]

Meanwhile, in the west of Afghanistan, there were anxieties that Teheran was busy stirring things up near the Persian border. D'Arcy Todd, the officer who taken on the difficult job of trying to win over the Wazir of Herat, Yar Mohammad Alikozai, had fulfilled Burnes's prediction of the inevitable collapse of his mission by failing to stop the growing rapprochement between the Heratis and the Persians. The final straw was when Yar Mohammad had simply pocketed a large sum of money Todd had given him to finance an attack on the Persian-occupied border fortress of Ghorian. Increasingly convinced that Yar Mohammad was intending to ally himself with Persia and lead an Islamic coalition against Shah Shuja and his British backers, on 10 February 1841 Todd had left his post without official permission and marched back to Kandahar, effectively breaking off diplomatic relations. In due course, Yar Mohammad had Shuja's cousin, Kamran Shah Sadozai, arrested and strangled, so taking over control of the city in name as well as in letter. He then promptly entered into an anti-British alliance with Mohammad Shah of Persia.[14]

Even more threatening was the situation to the south and west of Kandahar, where both the Durranis and the formidable Tokhi and Hotaki Ghilzais had risen up against the British in Helmand and Qalat. Although it